

The Korea Times, January 16, 2006

Police, Army Robots To Debut In Five Years

THE INCURABLE KOREAN desire to be at the forefront of technology is obvious again. How long before you thought Robocop would hit the streets? Twenty years? Ten? The Korea Times' Kim Tae-gyu tells us otherwise...

By the 2010s, Korea is expecting to see robots assisting police and the military, patrolling the neighborhoods and going on recon missions on the battlefield.

The Center for Intelligent Robots on Monday said the state-backed agency plans to check the feasibility of security robots by convening a 40-member planning committee late this week.

"If the robots prove to be viable technically and commercially, we will be able to begin developing them late next year," said Lee Ho-gil, head of the center.

When completed, the outdoor security robots will be able to make their night watch rounds and even chase criminals, according to Lee.

The government also seeks to build combat robots. They will take the shape of

a dog or a horse, with six or eight legs or wheels.

Toward that end, the Ministry of Information and Communication (MIC) and the Defense Ministry will combine to channel a total of 33.4 billion won (\$33.9 million) through 2011.

"The robots will be directed by a remote control system or move autonomously via their own artificial intelligence systems," MIC project manager Oh Sang-rok said.

"The two sophisticated robots will be empowered by the country's state-of-the-art mobile network, thus enabling mass production at an affordable price," Oh noted.

"In a nutshell, the mobile robot offers a hardware platform for the smart functions provided by the country's advanced network connected to the super computers," Oh said.

On top of their use in national defense and social security, the MIC hopes to use the network robots for the private sector late this year.

"Three kinds of household machines will commercially debut this October. They will sell for 1-2 million won, a price that will not scare off customers. The low price is possible since they are empowered by outside networks instead of incorporated software," Oh said.

The three sorts of wheeled robots will be used for various applications: cleaning rooms, health-care programs, Internet connection, home monitoring or reading books to kids.

The mechanical servants, some of which have the ability to re-charge automatically, can also order Chinese food and pizza by connecting to the local network.

The MIC already finished a test run of the household robots late last year by installing them in 64 households and two post offices in Seoul and its vicinity.

Hyung Tae-gun, director general at the MIC, expected the robots will sell up to 3,000 units for this year alone and the sales will surge in the near future.

"Recently Japan unveiled household service robots priced at up to 10 million won, almost 10 times as expensive as ours. So you can guess the competitiveness of our network robots," Hyung said.



Wired.com, December 19, 2005

Not With A Bang But A Whimper

THE IMPENDING PLUG-PULLING of Asheron's Call 2—the MMORPG—got Wired.com's Clive Thompson in a reflective and forlorn mood.

"Anybody out there?" I type, but I already know it's pointless. There's nobody anywhere near me. For almost an hour, I've been wandering around a desolate plain: Gray clouds scud slowly over rough quartz mountains, while a few birds wheel in the air near mushroom-shaped trees. I never see another living soul. It feels like the end of the world.

And in fact, it is. I'm inside Asheron's Call 2, an online game that is scheduled to die in two weeks. It never acquired enough players to make it self-sufficient, so the game's owner—Turbine—is going to do something that only happens rarely in the world of online play: On Dec. 30, it'll flip the power off on the remaining servers, and an entire world will blink out of existence.

This got me wondering: How do people behave in a world where the end is actually nigh? Sci-fi aficionados,

Cold War moviemakers and Christian apocalyptics have mused over this for years, since they've assumed that the end of life would have a catalytic effect on the human spirit. In nuclear-war or alien-invasion films like The Day After or War of the Worlds, catastrophic attacks turn America into a landscape of venal looting and family togetherness—our best impulses mixed with our worst.

But after talking to several longtime players of Asheron's Call 2, I've realized the end of a game world is less cataclysmic—and more subtle. The players aren't dying in real life; they're just being forced to disband. Their emotional state is thus more like the grief of an indigenous tribe that is being driven off its land by a megacorporation and is losing its way of life. It's kind of like the villagers at the end of Fiddler on the Roof, forced by the czar to abandon their homes and scatter to the four winds.

"It's really heart-wrenching. How will you connect with those people you spent every single day with? It's as though someone suddenly took away all e-mail," as one player who calls herself "Ellen Ripley" online told me. "Suddenly they seem nameless and ethereal, where once they were as real and important as our families, co-workers and Earth-realm friends."

Online worlds are, of course, more than just playlands for slaughtering ogres and collecting magic chain mail. They're social hangouts where players sit around shooting the breeze about their lives, their jobs, their favorite music. "That gives one an odd sense of home. And no one likes to see their homes be demolished," said Chris Thorn, a 26-year-old player in Arlington, Virginia.

The economy has also tanked. When the announcement first came down, players say, a majority of gamers immediately fled. Previously, you'd log on and find several hundred people online; now you'll get nine or 10. High-powered character accounts used to sell for as much as \$500, but the online auctions have gone silent. That's partly because, as the end nears, Turbine is tossing out some freebies and giving away more "rare" items, making them less rare. Without a sense of a future, capitalism ends. There's no demand in a condemned world.



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